

Time to change professions?

Happy New Year, folks! Hope all of you are raring to go in 2023, chasing dreams and doing the best in everything that you can. I don't know why but I'm not feeling very cheerful at the time of writing this column, finding myself in a gloomy mood as far as the future of everything is concerned. Thanks in no small part to the scary pace of AI advancements, in particular OpenAI's ChatGPT, which poses a significant threat to people like me who write and create written content here at Digit to earn a living for me and my family.

If you've been active on social media, especially Twitter and LinkedIn, then you must've noticed how everyone and their granny were discussing ChatGPT's incredible prose prowess. In fact, ChatGPT has been one of the top 10 trending topics of 2022, surprising and amazing people from all walks of life with its limitless ability to create content from scratch. Yes, this is no exaggeration, ask ChatGPT a random question or command it to spit out facts on any topic that you can think of and it magically does so in just a few seconds. Until earlier this year, I was under the impression that AI chatbots were still largely a gimmicky hook employed by companies to waste people's time and save their own call centre costs. But some time spent with ChatGPT is enough to convince me that it is going to replace the way content is generated and pumped out in the very near future. In fact, it's already happening right now.

AI-aided writing support for grammar or typo correction in Google Docs or Grammarly seems low-level compared to what OpenAI's ChatGPT can accomplish. Everything from Ryan Reynolds' AI-generated script for his latest Mint Mobile advertisement to publishers like CNET using ChatGPT for generating articles on certain topics, from functioning like a search engine to rival the likes of Google to debugging complex code written by programmers, from generating executive summaries of complex essays to even providing accurate medical information, there's nothing that ChatGPT can't do in the blink of an eye. Or so it would seem... at least for now.



“How will my young daughter, who's still in primary school and already consulting YouTube and Alexa in her homework, ever do anything original anymore without taking shortcuts?”

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The implications of this are enormous, scary enough to start worrying about your job now and what you should be doing in the future – I definitely am thinking along these lines for sure. Not out of plain fear but a healthy dose of pragmatism. What ChatGPT is doing to writers, AI art tools like DALL-E, Midjourney and Stable Diffusion are doing to designers and graphics artists. Another immediate thought in my mind is about the increasingly AI-dependent world my daughter will grow up in. How will my young daughter, who's still in primary school and already consulting YouTube and Alexa in her homework, ever do anything original anymore without taking shortcuts?

If AI will progressively invade her life to make things ever so convenient for every imaginable task, how will she learn the value of figuring things out on her own through trial and error? Sure, the good old “AI will free us up for doing more meaningful work” comes to mind, but how will we derive meaning from our work if everything we do is heavily influenced by artificial intelligence systems? Sure ChatGPT cannot outwit perhaps the highest forms of original human thought – how can we expect that of a mere chatbot? – but what if we lose our sense of originality or ability to think out of the box by simply over prioritising AI-enabled convenience over everything else in the near future?

Of course, I may be barking mad, and everything I've felt and conveyed about my own unease towards the unintended consequences of AI progress may be all wrong. In fact, there may be nothing to fear, as my friend and ex-Digit team member Nikhil Pradhan conveys in his take on the matter (please go read - <https://digit.in/nikhil>). Just like artists and graphics designers will have to evolve and use AI art tools to their advantage, writers have no choice but to do the same with ChatGPT. All the same, I know I'm going to try and upskill myself as best as I can through this year and beyond, hoping to co-exist with AI in harmony and peace. **d**